Pluto Gets the Call

By Adam Rex

INTRODUCTION

For 76 years, Pluto was the beloved ninth planet in our solar system. No one cared that he/she was the runt of the solar system, with a moon half his/her size. NO one minded that he/she had a tilted, oval-shaped orbit. Pluto was a weirdo, but he/she was our weirdo.

But then one day in 2006, Pluto gets a call from some scientists on Earth, and they have some bad news — he/she actually ***isn't*** *a planet anymore. The International Astronomical Union (or IAU) had redefined the word "planet." And Pluto no longer fits the bill. As you can imagine, Pluto isn't too happy with this news, so he sets out on a journey through the solar system to find out why.*

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PLUTO: Ooh, someone's going to call? Are they calling to invoice me to a party? I LOVE parties! *(waving broadly)* Hi . . . Hi! . . . Over here! Behind the ice and all those other guys. It's me, Pluto! The ninth planet! It's great to see you! We don't get a lot of visitors out here in the Kuiper Belt. It's this huge ring around the Sun that's full of frozen stuff. It's kind of my neighborhood, no big deal. *(beat)* So, not to brag, but I'm mostly made of nitrogen.

STAR: Ooh, nitrogen! *(swoons)*

PLUTO: I'm almost as big as Earth's moon. I'm really cold, and I have a big heart on my belly 'cause I love being a planet. Hold on a second, that's my phone. *(on the phone)* You got Pluto! Oh, what a coincidence – I was just talking to someone from Earth. *(to audience)* Sorry, I should take this. *(back on the phone)* Uh-huh . . . Uh-huh . . What?! What do you mean I'm not a planet anymore? Why am I not a planet anymore. I . . . Uh . . . okay. Thank you for calling. *(to audience)* That was just some scientists from Earth. They say I'm not a planet anymore, no biggie. *(getting angry)* They asked if I'd like to be known as the solar system's largest ice dwarf, and I was like, "How'd you like to known as Earth's . . . meanest . . . jerks, huh? Huh?! *(sadness set in)* I didn't really say that. I'm sorry, you were probably hoping to hang out with a ***real*** planet. Let me show you around. *(travels to the closest neighbor)* Psst, Neptune! Are you awake?

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NEPTUNE: *(obviously waking up from a nap)* Mweh?

PLUTO: This is Neptune. He's closer to the Sun than me, but he's still to far away that it takes him 65 years to orbit all the way around! It only takes Earth one year! One year exactly! That's what a year is, actually.

STAR: AHHHHH! A black hole . . . . Don't get sucked in!

NEPTUNE: *(still groggy)* Who are you talking to?

PLUTO: *(To Neptune)* No one, man, go back to sleep. *(To audience)* Neptune is pretty icy. *(Neptune farts and Pluto reacts)* And gassy. I'm not being mean, he just is. His twin is called Uranus – they're practically the same size.

URANUS: Hey, Pluto!

STAR: Don't mind Uranus. She always spins on her side! So do her rings!

MOON: When did she get rings? I want rings!

PLUTO: Uranus is icy, too. In fact, she and Neptune are called ice giants, which is . . . *(sadly)* which is why they want to call me an ice dwarf, I guess.

URANUS: What's up, Pluto? I know you have a kind of a funky orbit, but I don't usually see you this close to the Sun.

PLUTO: These Earth scientists say I'm not a planet anymore.

URANUS: WHAT?

PLUTO: Hold on, there's my phone. Oh, look, it's the scientists again *(rolls eyes)*

URANUS: *(repositioning herself)* Am I back in place?

STAR: Down a little to the left. *(Uranus follows directions)*

PLUTO: *(on the phone)* What do YOU want? *(with attitude)* No, as a matter of fact, I don't want to be called a "plutoid." Would you like to be called a "humanoid?" Sheesh! Hanging up! *(to Uranus)* I gotta go, Uranus.

URANUS: Stay frosty.

PLUTO: Next up are Saturn and Jupiter. They're gas giants. Again, I am **not** making these names up.

SATURN: Hi, Pluto!

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PLUTO: Hi, yourself! *(to audience)* Saturn has AMAZING rings!)

SATURN: Oh, stop!

PLUTO: They look like solid bands from far away, but really they're made up of little bits of ice and rock and dust.

SATURN: *(embarrassed, but loving it)* Oh, stop, stop, stop, STOP! Uh . . . hey, look over there! It's Jupiter!

JUPITER: *(angrily)* STOP LOOKING AT ME!

PLUTO: *(whispers to audience)* He's a big ball of gas!

JUPITER: YOU'RE A BIG BALL OF GAS!

PLUTO: I'm . . . not, though. I'm little and I have a hard surface you can stand on. But Saturn and Jupiter don't! If you tried to sand on Jupiter, you'd just fall right through him.

JUPITER: KEEP OFF THE GAS!

SATURN: You know, Jupiter . . . he's really stormy. That Great Red Spot is a storm! It's bigger than Earth, and it's been there for as long as I can remember.

JUPITER: I'M BIGGER THAN ALL YOU PLANETS PUT TOGETHER!

Pluto: Uhhhh, I should go.

SATURN: Bye, Pluto! Call me!

PLUTO: *(dodging asteroids and comets)* Jeez. There's a lot of garbage between Jupiter and Mars.

ASTEROID: Oh, nice. It's Pluto, calling **us** garbage.

COMET: We're not "garbage." We're bits of rocks called asteroids and comets.

ASTEROID: Together we're called the Asteroid Belt.

PLUTO: Sorry! Gosh, I'm sorry.

ASTEROID: Just because he's a planet, he thinks he's better than us!

ASTEROID 2: What about Ceres? He's pretty big. He orbits around the sun! He's round like a planet!

CERES: *(confronting Pluto)* Yeah, that's right! How come you're a planet and I'm not?

PLUTO: I'm . . . actually not a planet anymore.

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CERES: He's not a planet anymore? HA! HA! He's not a planet anymore. *(Asteroid, Comet and Ceres laugh and point)*

PLUTO: I don't have to take this! I am OUT OF HERE! *(travels closer to the SUN, obviously warm, sweaty)* Um. So, there's Mars. She's smaller than Earth, and she has a lot of water ice.

ASTEROID: I don't see any water ice.

STAR: It's under her surface. It's part ice, water, dust, and small rocks.

COMET: That's exactly what I put in my smoothies!

PLUTO: She's called the Red Planet because of all the rusty iron on her surface. Hi, Mars!

MARS: *(paranoid)* I have robots on me.

PLUTO: Yeah?

MARS: Some of them just sit there. Some of them roll around. *(Pluto and Mars look at each other incredulously)* ROBOTS!! *(whispers)* The humans sent them here.

PLUTO: UGH! No offense, but I don't want to talk about humans right now. *(Pluto leaves in a huff)* So next is Earth. *(raises hand as if "talk to the hand" and looks the other direction in a major snub)* It's where mean scientists live – moving on!

EARTH: Oh, c'mon!

STAR: Look, there's Earth's moon! Guess who has the MOST moons.

STAR 2: *super excited)* Um, Mars! No, Neptune! Wait, Uranus! No, Mercury! Ooh, ooh, it's Venus! I mean, Saturn! It's Saturn, isn't it?

STAR: *(exasperated)* Jupiter.

STAR 2: Awww, I was going to say that!

STAR: Wow! Pluto has traveled over 3.5 billion miles!

PLUTO: Venus and Mercury are really hot.

MERCURY: You're not so bad yourself.

PLUTO: Venus is the hottest planet, and she's hidden behind yellow acid clouds.

VENUS: *(ashamed)* You'd hide your face too if it was covered in volcanoes.

PLUTO: Mercury's hot too, but he's also cold!

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MERCURY: *(Sings a line from Foreigner)* Cold as Ice!

PLUTO: If you were standing on Mercury in the Sun, you'd burn up. But if you stood in the shade, you'd freeze.

VENUS: Hey, Pluto, are you doing okay?

PLUTO: Oh, I'm just kind of down because I'm not a planet anymore.

VENUS: Not a planet? But you're round.

PLUTO: Yeah.

MERCURY: You orbit the Sun. You don't orbit another planet like a moon does.

PLUTO: Yeah, but I live in a crowded neighborhood. I guess a real planet's supposed to sweep all the ice and rocks out of the way.

VENUS: Hey, why don't you go talk to the boss about this?

PLUTO: Maybe I will!

MERCURY: Yeah, man! Go ask the Sun's advice – she's pretty bright. *(laughing at his own joke, when no one else laughs, he tries to explain)* Did you get what I said? Pretty bright? Because she's the Sun.

PLUTO: Yeah, no. I got it. *(traveling onward)*

SUN: Pluto! You're far from home!

PLUTO: *(sadly)* Did you hear what happened to me?

SUN: *(nodding)* Pluto, you were orbiting around me for billions of years before the word "planet" was even invented.

PLUTO: Oh, I know. I just liked feeling special for a while.

SUN: Look out at the solar system, my friend. *(gazing out into the distance)* Mercury is the smallest.

MERCURY: And, dare I say, the cutest!

SUN: Venus is the hottest.

VENUS: *(spinning in circles)* And I rotate in the opposite direction as most everyone else.

SUN: Earth has life.

EARTH: *(has just taken a bite and speaks with a full mouth)* And this yummy sandwich!

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SUN: Mars has robots.

MARS: I ***guess*** they're kind of cool.

SUN: Jupiter's the biggest.

JUPITER: Stop Staring at my red spot. *(covers himself)*

SUN: Saturn has its rings.

SATURN: *(waving with both hands)* Yoo-hoo! Hi, Pluto!

SUN: People talk about Uranus for reasons I don't really want to get into.

URANUS: *(turns and begins to bend over, then rethinks it)* Aww, shucks, you must mean my charming personality.

SUN: And . . . well, Neptune is Neptune . . .

NEPTUNE: What's THAT supposed to mean?

SUN: *(gearing up for a rousing pep talk)* But you, Pluto . . . you're the planet who doesn't get to be a planet anymore. And people love you for it. You're still a planet to everyone who was too short to ride the Ferris wheel. To everyone who's ever put seven dollars into a claw machine and still didn't get the hippopotamus they wanted. To all the people picked last for kickball. Do you know that right now, as we speak, those scientists are still arguing about you?

PLUTO: They are?

SUN: You used to be the coldest, littlest planet . . but now you have a big warm place in our hearts.

EARTH: There, there, don't cry Jupiter

JUPITER: *(obviously crying)* I'm not crying. I have . . . meteor dust in my eyes!

PLUTO: Thanks, Sun. . . I'd hug you, but . . .

SUN: You'd burn up instantly. It's cool.

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AWARD HISTORY

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